

NovaTech Solutions Inc.

Employee HR Policy Handbook

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People & Culture Department

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1. Employment & Equal Opportunity Policy

Policy Ref: HR-EMP-001 | Owner: Talent Acquisition | Review: Annual

1.1 Equal Employment Opportunity (EEO)

NovaTech Solutions Inc. is firmly committed to providing equal employment opportunity to all individuals regardless of race, color, religion, sex, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, national origin, ancestry, age, disability, marital status, veteran status, genetic information, or any other characteristic protected by applicable federal, state, or local law.

All employment decisions — including hiring, promotion, compensation, training, and termination — are based solely on legitimate, job-related criteria. Managers and hiring teams must adhere to structured interview frameworks and documented scoring rubrics to minimize unconscious bias.

- Recruitment ads must use inclusive language reviewed by the DEI (Diversity, Equity & Inclusion) team.
- Interview panels must include at least one member from an underrepresented group where feasible.
- Accommodation requests for persons with disabilities must be escalated to HR within 2 business days.

1.2 At-Will Employment

Unless otherwise specified in a signed employment contract, all employment at NovaTech is at-will. This means either the employee or the Company may terminate the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause, subject to applicable notice period requirements outlined in Section 10 of this handbook.

1.3 Background Verification

All offers of employment are contingent upon successful completion of background verification, conducted by an authorized third-party agency. Verification includes identity check, educational credentials, previous employment history (up to 7 years), criminal record check (where permitted), and reference checks from at least two former supervisors.

Results are treated as strictly confidential. Adverse findings are reviewed on a case-by-case basis with legal counsel before any employment decision is made.

2. Compensation & Benefits Policy

Policy Ref: HR-COMP-002 | Owner: Total Rewards | Review: Annual

2.1 Salary Structure & Pay Cycles

NovaTech follows a market-linked, band-based compensation philosophy benchmarked annually against industry salary surveys (Mercer, Aon Hewitt). Each role is assigned a Job Level (JL1–JL9) with a corresponding salary band (minimum, midpoint, maximum).

Job Level	Band
JL1 – JL2 (Associate)	Entry-level individual contributors
JL3 – JL4 (Specialist)	Mid-level individual contributors
JL5 – JL6 (Senior / Lead)	Senior ICs and team leads
JL7 – JL8 (Manager / Director)	People managers
JL9 (VP & Above)	Executive leadership

Salaries are disbursed on the **last working day of each calendar month** via direct bank transfer. Pay slips are available on the self-service HR portal (MyNova) by the 3rd of the following month.

2.2 Performance Bonus & Incentives

Eligible employees receive an Annual Performance Bonus (APB) based on individual performance rating and company financial achievement. Bonus pools are allocated as a percentage of annual CTC:

Rating	Bonus Range (% of Annual CTC)
Exceptional (5)	18% – 25%
Exceeds Expectations (4)	12% – 17%
Meets Expectations (3)	6% – 11%
Partially Meets (2)	0% – 5%
Does Not Meet (1)	0% (PIP initiated)

2.3 Health & Wellness Benefits

NovaTech provides comprehensive Group Medical Insurance (GMI) coverage effective from the date of joining:

- Employee + Spouse + up to 2 dependent children: Sum Insured ■5,00,000 per annum.
- Parents / In-laws: Optional top-up cover at subsidized group premium.
- Dental & Vision: Reimbursement up to ■15,000 per year on production of receipts.
- Employee Assistance Program (EAP): 8 free confidential counseling sessions per year.
- Annual Health Check-up: Fully sponsored preventive health package at empaneled hospitals.

2.4 Retirement & Provident Fund

Contributions to the Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) are made at 12% of basic salary by both employee and employer, per the EPF & MP Act, 1952. NovaTech additionally provides a Gratuity benefit per the Payment of Gratuity Act after completion of 5 years of continuous service.

3. Leave & Time-Off Policy

Policy Ref: HR-LVE-003 | Owner: People Operations | Review: Annual

Leave Type	Entitlement	Carryforward	Encashable
Privilege Leave (PL)	18 days/year	Up to 30 days	Yes (max 15 days)
Sick Leave (SL)	12 days/year	None	No
Casual Leave (CL)	6 days/year	None	No
Maternity Leave	26 weeks	N/A	No
Paternity Leave	10 days	None	No
Bereavement Leave	5 days	N/A	No
Compensatory Off	As earned	30 days	No
Sabbatical (5+ yr service)	Up to 3 months	N/A	No

3.1 Leave Application & Approval

All leaves must be applied via the MyNova HR portal a minimum of **3 working days in advance** for planned leaves. Emergency or unplanned leave must be intimated to the reporting manager via phone/message before 9:30 AM on the day of absence, followed by portal entry on return.

Leaves of 3 or more consecutive days require supporting documentation (medical certificate for sick leave; event proof for bereavement). Misrepresentation of leave purpose is grounds for disciplinary action.

3.3 Parental Leave

Maternity leave is provided as per the Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017: 26 weeks for the first two children and 12 weeks for subsequent children. Adoption and surrogacy provisions follow the same legislative framework. All parental leave is paid and job-protected.

4. Code of Conduct & Workplace Ethics

Policy Ref: HR-COD-004 | Owner: Legal & Compliance | Review: Bi-Annual

4.1 Professional Conduct Standards

Every NovaTech employee is expected to act with integrity, professionalism, and respect in all interactions — internal and external. The following behaviors are mandatory:

- Treat all colleagues, clients, vendors, and visitors with dignity and courtesy.
- Represent NovaTech accurately and truthfully in all external communications.
- Maintain punctuality and meet committed deadlines; proactively communicate delays.
- Exercise responsible use of company resources including IT assets, office supplies, and time.
- Adhere to all applicable laws, regulations, and contractual obligations relevant to your role.
- Dress code: Business casual in office; follow client-site standards when visiting customers.

4.2 Conflict of Interest

Employees must avoid situations where personal interests could conflict or appear to conflict with the interests of NovaTech. A Conflict of Interest (COI) declaration must be submitted annually via MyNova and immediately upon occurrence of any triggering event, including:

- Holding a financial interest (>1% equity) in a competitor, supplier, or customer.
- Engaging in paid outside employment or consulting in a related domain without prior written approval.
- A family member being employed at, or seeking business with, NovaTech.
- Serving on an external board of directors without prior disclosure.

Note: Disclosure alone does not authorize the activity. HR and Legal review each COI and determine required mitigation — recusal, divestiture, or approval may be required.

4.3 Confidentiality & Data Privacy

Employees have access to confidential information including trade secrets, financial data, customer information, product roadmaps, and personnel records. All employees must sign a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA) at the time of joining, which remains in effect for **2 years post-separation**.

Handling of personal data of employees and customers is governed by the NovaTech Data Privacy Policy (DPP-001) and applicable data protection regulations including GDPR (where applicable) and India's DPDP Act 2023. Violations may result in disciplinary action and legal liability.

5. Anti-Harassment & Non-Discrimination Policy

Policy Ref: HR-AH-005 | Owner: POSH Committee / HR | Review: Annual

5.1 Zero-Tolerance Policy

NovaTech maintains a strict zero-tolerance policy against all forms of harassment, including sexual harassment, bullying, intimidation, and discrimination based on any protected characteristic. This policy applies to all employees, contractors, interns, and third-party personnel across all company premises, work-related travel, virtual workspaces, and company-sponsored events.

Sexual harassment is defined broadly to include unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and any verbal, non-verbal, or physical conduct of a sexual nature that creates a hostile or offensive work environment. This includes conduct over digital communication channels.

5.2 Reporting Mechanisms

Complaints may be filed through any of the following confidential channels:

- Internal Complaints Committee (ICC): posh.committee@novatech.com | ICC Chairperson: Ms. Anita Krishnamurthy
- HR Helpline: hr.helpline@novatech.com | +91-80-4120-7799 (Mon–Fri, 9 AM–6 PM IST)
- Anonymous Ethics Hotline: ethics.novatech.com (managed by independent third party)
- Direct escalation to CHRO for senior leadership complaints: chro@novatech.com

Retaliation against any employee who reports harassment in good faith is strictly prohibited and is itself a disciplinable offense.

5.3 Investigation Process

Upon receipt of a complaint, the ICC/HR will acknowledge within **48 hours**. A formal investigation will commence within **7 working days**, conducted by a team of at least three members (including one external member for ICC cases). The process includes:

- Preliminary inquiry to assess whether prima facie case exists (completed within 10 days).
- Full investigation with interviews of complainant, respondent, and witnesses (max 60 days).
- Finding report submitted to management with recommendations for action.
- Outcome communicated to both parties; disciplinary action imposed per severity.
- Right to appeal: either party may appeal within 30 days to an appellate panel.

6. Performance Management

Policy Ref: HR-PER-006 | Owner: People Partnering | Review: Annual

6.1 Goal Setting & OKRs

NovaTech uses the OKR (Objectives and Key Results) framework for goal-setting, cascaded from company level to team and individual level. OKRs are set at the beginning of each quarter and reviewed at mid-quarter check-ins. Individual OKRs must be:

- Aligned with team and company-level OKRs (vertical alignment).
- Ambitious yet achievable; typical attainment target is 70–80% for stretch OKRs.
- Documented and finalized in MyNova by end of Day 10 of each quarter.
- At least 3 and no more than 5 Objectives with 2–4 KRs each.

6.2 Mid-Year & Annual Reviews

Performance cycles follow a bi-annual cadence: **Mid-Year Review (July)** and **Annual Appraisal (April)**. The annual review drives promotion decisions, compensation adjustments, and bonus payouts. The process involves self-assessment, manager evaluation, calibration across the team, and skip-level review for ratings of 4 and above.

6.3 Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)

Employees receiving a rating of 1 (Does Not Meet Expectations) or 2 (Partially Meets) for two consecutive cycles will be placed on a formal Performance Improvement Plan (PIP). A PIP:

- Lasts a minimum of 60 days and maximum of 90 days.
- Specifies measurable improvement milestones with weekly manager check-ins.
- Requires sign-off by the employee, manager, HR Business Partner, and department head.
- Successful completion results in performance plan closure; failure may result in termination.

7. Learning & Development

Policy Ref: HR-LND-007 | Owner: L&D; CoE | Review: Annual

7.1 Training Budget & Allowances

Every full-time employee is allocated an annual Learning & Development (L&D;) budget as follows: JL1–JL4: ■20,000/year; JL5–JL6: ■35,000/year; JL7–JL8: ■60,000/year; JL9+: ■1,00,000/year. Budget may be used for external courses, certifications, conferences, and professional memberships with prior manager and HR approval. Unused budget does not roll over.

7.2 Internal Learning Programs

NovaTech Learning Hub (NLH) offers curated internal programs accessible to all employees:

- TechFluent Academy: Bi-monthly technical bootcamps in Cloud, AI/ML, DevSecOps, and Data Engineering.
- LeadForward Program: 6-month leadership development cohort for JL5+ employees (50 seats/year).
- Mentorship Circles: Structured peer and cross-functional mentorship program with quarterly pairings.
- Lunch & Learn: Weekly 45-minute expert talks recorded for on-demand playback on NLH.

- Certification Reimbursement: 100% reimbursement for pre-approved technical certifications (AWS, GCP, Azure, PMP, CPA, etc.).

8. Remote Work & Flexible Work Arrangements

Policy Ref: HR-RW-008 | Owner: Workplace Strategy | Review: Semi-Annual

8.1 Hybrid Work Guidelines

NovaTech operates a structured hybrid model. Employees are expected to be present in the office a **minimum of 3 days per week (Tuesdays, Wednesdays, and Thursdays are anchor days)**. Mondays and Fridays are flexible remote days by default. Exceptions based on project criticality may be invoked by the reporting manager with at least 48 hours' notice.

Fully remote arrangements may be approved for roles designated as remote-eligible by the HRBP and functional leader, subject to annual review. Employees on fully remote arrangements located outside the registered work state/country require additional legal and tax review.

- Core collaboration hours (mandatory online availability): 10:00 AM – 4:00 PM local time.
- Meeting-free Fridays: No internal meetings to be scheduled on Fridays (exceptions: client-critical).
- Time zone overlap: Employees working from a different geography must maintain 4+ hours of overlap.

8.2 Work-From-Home Equipment Policy

NovaTech provides a one-time WFH setup allowance of **■25,000** (JL1–JL6) or **■40,000** (JL7+) for ergonomic chair, desk, and peripherals, reimbursed upon submission of receipts. All company-issued laptops must comply with the IT Security Policy (IT-SEC-012) — screen lock, VPN usage, and encrypted storage are mandatory when working remotely.

9. Disciplinary & Grievance Procedures

Policy Ref: HR-DIS-009 | Owner: Employee Relations | Review: Annual

9.1 Progressive Discipline Framework

NovaTech uses a progressive discipline approach, though severity of offense may bypass earlier steps. The framework includes:

Step	Action	Documentation
Step 1	Verbal Warning	Noted in manager log; emailed to HR
Step 2	Written Warning (Memo)	Signed by employee; filed in HR record
Step 3	Final Written Warning / Suspension	HR & Legal review; may include unpaid suspension
Step 4	Termination for Cause	Approved by HR Head & Business Unit Head

Gross misconduct (e.g., fraud, theft, violence, POSH violation) may result in immediate termination without prior warning steps, pending investigation.

9.2 Grievance Redressal Process

Employees with a workplace grievance are encouraged to first raise it informally with their direct manager. If unresolved within 5 working days, a formal grievance may be filed through HR Helpdesk. HR will acknowledge within 2 days and aim to resolve within 21 working days. An escalation path to the CHRO exists for unresolved formal grievances.

10. Separation & Offboarding Policy

Policy Ref: HR-SEP-010 | Owner: People Operations | Review: Annual

10.1 Resignation Procedure

Employees wishing to resign must submit a formal resignation letter via MyNova or email to their manager and HR Business Partner. Notice periods are as follows:

Job Level	Notice Period
JL1 – JL4	30 calendar days
JL5 – JL6	60 calendar days
JL7 – JL8	90 calendar days
JL9 & Above	As per individual employment contract (typically 90–180 days)

Notice periods may be waived (buy-out) by mutual written agreement. Garden leave may be granted at NovaTech's discretion during the notice period for sensitive roles.

10.2 Involuntary Termination

Termination initiated by the Company (without cause, such as role elimination) triggers the following severance entitlements:

- Severance pay: 1 month's gross salary per year of completed service (max 12 months).
- Continuation of medical insurance coverage for 60 days post last working day.
- Outplacement support services for impacted employees (career coaching, resume review, referrals).
- All accrued but unused Privilege Leave will be encashed at the time of settlement.

10.3 Exit Clearance & Full & Final (F&F;) Settlement

On or before the last working day, the separating employee must complete an exit clearance checklist covering: IT asset return, access revocation, knowledge transfer documentation, project handover, and finance clearances (expense advances, asset liability). The Full & Final settlement — including pending salary, PL encashment, gratuity (if applicable), and deductions — will be processed within **45 days of the last working day** per applicable law.

An exit interview is strongly encouraged and may be conducted by HR in a confidential setting. Feedback is anonymized and used to improve the employee experience.

Acknowledgment: All employees are required to read, understand, and acknowledge this handbook via the MyNova portal within 7 days of joining or upon policy update notification. This document supersedes all prior versions. NovaTech reserves the right to amend policies with reasonable notice. Queries: hr.help@novatech.com